THE TRUTH IS AN INHABITANT OF EVERY PLACE

On an ordinary day in February 1580 the inhabitants of Fatehpur Sikri were startled by a remarkable sight. Accompanied by a Mughal cavalcade, as well as some Armenian and European traders, were some bizarre-looking travellers. Crowds lined the streets and gawked openly at these men. ‘Everyone stopped and stared in great surprise and perplexity,’ admitted Monserrate, ‘wondering who these strange-looking, unarmed men might be, with their long robes, their curious caps, their shaven faces, and their tonsured heads.’ Their smooth, pale faces glowed blotchily with sweat in the warm day and almost more striking was that none of them bore any weapons. In the Mughal court, every man had a katar (Rajasthani-style dagger) tucked into his patka, or cummerbund, and a smoothly curved scimitar hanging at the waist and perhaps a jewelled dagger for good measure. Even the gentle, otherworldly musician Tansen had a jewelled sword, and the theologians all had long staffs and rods. These foreign men, however, were unarmed and unadorned, bearing only their faith, and a burning desire to proselytize.

The Jesuit priests were hustled away from the boisterous throng and brought before Akbar, who had been eagerly awaiting their arrival. ‘The Fathers found the great conqueror,’ we are told by Monserrate, ‘seated cross-legged on a throne covered with a velvet cushion fringed with gold, upon a raised platform.’ All around him were his great amirs, splendidly dressed in silk jamas and crisp turbans studded with glittering jewels. When they looked up at the Padshah, the Jesuits found that Akbar ‘was almost as fair as southern Europeans, and…upon his head he wore a turban of Hindu form, adorned with a fortune of rare gems. His dress consisted of a robe of cloth of gold, embroidered with leaves and flowers, a great brooch was on his breast. Instead of Moslem trousers, he wore the Hindu dhoti of the finest and most delicate silk, falling to his heels, and there gathered in by bangles covered with pearls…. At his side was a scimitar.’ Around the Padshah were attendants bearing bows and quivers of arrows, daggers, scimitars, and muskets, were he to require them, while writers waited quietly, ready to note down anything of importance. Akbar greeted his visitors with great